intentions. Continuity in relations with the Soviet Union ultimately prevailed, given India's persisting regional concerns and economic limitations. But the warming in relations with the United States was indicative of a gradual shift away from dependence on the Soviet Union, which accelerated with the Soviet collapse in 1991.

The structural shift

India, with the loss of its key patron and economic distress in the 1990s, pushed forward the economic liberalisation initiated under Rajiv Gandhi. This movement contributed to close ties with Washington. Yet with economic liberalisation came opportunities for greater foreign investment and an effort to diversify defence relationships. By the end of the 1990s, India had secured defence agreements with Italy, South Africa, the United Kingdom, and the United States. Between 2000 and 2008, New Delhi secured another 19 defence agreements – a staggering change from the 7 total agreements secured in the first 53 years of independence.[23] Pakistan's slip from its privileged position in US foreign policy upon the collapse of the Soviet Union also injected energy into India's ties with the United States, but this was countered by the gap between the two countries in their respective stance on nuclear weapons. The Clinton administration's push for non-proliferation and India's reluctance to oblige led to mounting vexations on both sides that peaked when India rejected the US-led Comprehensive Test Ban Treaty in 1996 and carried out a series of nuclear weapon tests in 1998. Ironically, it was Pakistan that pushed India and the United States together through its incursions into Kargil in 1999. This event marked the first time the United States supported India against Pakistan. It was